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Peercite Journal of Women Leadership

ORIGINAL RESEARCH

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Beyond Resilience: The Evolving Leadership Mindset of Women Professionals

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Abstract:

Background: Research on women's leadership often focuses on impostor feelings, self-doubt, coping, and their effects on work, performance, and emotional well-being. Less attention is given to women's purposeful choices and to the organisational conditions that enable their contributions.

Objectives: To explore how experienced women professionals who have attained leadership roles describe their career journeys, and challenges, emotional well-being, and leadership development. The study also examines how participants practise resilience, what it enables, which organisational conditions may help make leadership sustainable.

Methods: This exploratory qualitative study draws on researcher-recorded notes from 13 semi-structured interviews conducted in English in October 2026. The accounts were organised into six interpretive themes using a thematic approach informed by Braun and Clarke.

Results: The themes addressed adaptive confidence, and career ownership, family priorities and everyday coping practices, and workplace recognition, mentoring, and informal support networks, and stakeholder relationships. Participants described both personal resourcefulness and organisational constraints. When self-doubt arose, participants generally described it as situational rather than enduring, and as manageable in context.

Discussion: A provisional Self-Determination–Support–Impact Frame work is proposed to interpret the relationship between purposeful individual action & organisational conditions that may support meaningful career deve -lopment. The framework is interpretive and has not been empirically tested.

Conclusion: The findings suggest that career development involves both individual decision-making institutional practice. The small, heterogeneous sample and reliance on interview notes limit transferability and do not support causal claims.

Keywords: women leaders; resilience; self-determination; qualitative research ; career ownership; mentoring; psychological safety;

Introduction:

India presents a striking contrast in women's leadership. In the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2025, India ranked 131st of 148 countries and scored 40.7% on the economic participation and opportunity subindex (World Economic Forum, 2025). In contrast, women held 36.5% of senior management roles in Indian mid-market businesses, compared with a global average of 34% (Grant Thornton, 2025). Women who attain senior roles in India do so within strong societal and organisational constraints, sometimes while challenging them. This study addresses a tension in discussions of women's advancement. Workplace narratives often focus on confidence deficits, self-doubt, impostor feelings, work–life balance, and the challenges of succeeding in male-dominated environments. These type of experiences matter, particularly where women are under represented or perceive that recognition and rewards are not based on merit. At the same time, it is important to examine how women exercise judgement, and make consequential choices, use coping strategies, and sustain motivation in environments they may experience as unsupportive. The study draws on accounts from women leading teams or functions across sales, corporate leadership, client-facing

services, technology, healthcare-related industries, social-impact work, talent acquisition, and talent management. These settings involve varied expectations from organi--sations, and stakeholders, markets, internal customers, and business-development activities. The analytical focus is not whether women are sufficiently resilient. It is how resilience is practised, what it makes possible & which organisational conditions may allow it to support sustainable leadership rather than require perpetual individual accommodation. Rather than treating women's leadership journeys primarily as deficits in confidence or resilience, this study examines how experienced professionals make decisions, and seek recognition, plan for work and family responsibilities, establish boundaries, draw on personal and organisational resources. Research question: How do experienced women professionals describe their career journeys, including challenges and perceived bias; how do these experiences affect them emotionally; how do they respond and build support systems; how can organisations support women's careers and leadership development? The study aims to: (a) identify patterns and contrasts in confidence in relation to professional advancement; (b) examine how participants manage emotional and work–family demands; and (c) interpret the role of leadership relationships and workplace conditions in participants' accounts, including the strategies they use to navigate challenges and build resilience.

Review of Literature and Theoretical Back ground:

Women's leadership and career progression :

Eagly and Carli (2007) describe women's advancement as a labyrinth of recurring and varied barriers rather than a single glass ceiling. Organisational and the family-related barriers can shape career progression. Ibarra, Ely, and Kolb (2013) examine leadership identity transitions and how organisational expectations influence the recognition of women as leaders. Together, these perspectives locate career development within social, cultural, institutional conditions rather than treating advancement solely as a matter of individual confidence.

Self-doubt, confidence and professional identity:

The impostor phenomenon is often used to interpret professional self-doubt, but it should not be presumed to apply to every experienced woman professional. Bravata et al. (2020) review evidence on its prevalence and correlates, including associations with depression, and the anxiety, job performance, job satisfaction, and burnout across employee groups, including clinicians. This study therefore explores without assuming that they are experience it or assessing clinical outcomes. how participants describe self-doubt & its perceived effects,

Women's leadership and career progression :

Conservation of resources (COR) theory conceptualises stress as arising from the threat or actual loss of valued resources. It proposes that people seek to retain, protect, and build resources, and that access to resources can help mitigate stress (Hobfoll, 1989; Hobfoll et al., 2018). Research on work–family conflict and social support also highlights the relevance of support from supervisors and organisations, while recognising that context can shape these relationships (French et al., 2018; Kossek et al., 2011). Together, these perspectives suggest that sustainable professional engagement may depend on both personal strategies & access to organisational resources and support.

Organisational support, mentoring & psychological safety:

Edmondson (1999) defines team psychological safety as a shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking. Her study links psychological safety and learning behaviour to team performance. This perspective draws attention to how team structures, leadership, and shared beliefs may shape participation and learning. Ely, Ibarra, and Kolb (2011) argue that leadership development should take gendered organisational contexts into account. They critique approaches that simply add women to existing programmes or focus on "fixing" women, and instead conceptualise leadership development as identity work. Mentoring, sponsorship, and fair advancement systems are distinct forms of support. Their effectiveness, however, was not measured directly in the present study.

Research gap and conceptual positioning:

Edmondson (1999) defines team psychological safety as a shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking. Her study links psychological safety and learning behaviour to team performance. This perspective draws attention to how team structures, leadership, and shared beliefs may shape participation and learning. Ely, Ibarra, and Kolb (2011) argue that leadership development should take gendered organisational contexts into account. They critique approaches that simply add women to existing programmes or focus on "fixing" women, and instead conceptualise leadership development as identity work. Mentoring, sponsorship, and fair advancement systems are distinct forms of support. Their effectiveness, however, was not measured directly in the present study.

Research gap and conceptual positioning:

The literature addresses barriers to advancement, impostor feelings, work–family conflict and supportive environments. This study contributes an exploratory account of how experienced women describe everyday decisions involving professional ambition, personal values, relationships, and organisational conditions. The proposed framework was developed interpretively from the interview accounts; it was not experimentally tested.

Research Methodology;

Study design and research questions:

The study used an exploratory qualitative design based on semi-structured reflective interviews and interpretive thematic analysis. It focused on meaning and variation across accounts rather than estimating prevalence or testing hypotheses. Interview questions addressed confidence, self-doubt, challenges, perceived bias, emotional demands, family considerations, and organisational support.

Participants and sampling:

The analytic dataset comprised 13 participant records from professionals working in pharmaceuticals, finance, banking, technology, consulting, human resources, entrepreneurship, nonprofit organisations. Reported professional experience ranged from approximately 10 years to 30 years or more. Participants were experienced professionals from varied occupational contexts. Given the small qualitative sample, the findings are not statistically representative. Malterud et al. (2016) propose assessing information power in relation to the study aim, sample specificity, use of theory, quality of dialogue, and analytic strategy. The available notes and uneven coverage do not permit a definitive claim about sample adequacy or saturation.

Data collection and interview procedure:

According to the researcher, 13 semi-structured interviews were conducted online in English between 8 and 28 October 2026. Each interview lasted approximately 45–50 minutes. The interview guide covered professional journeys, and the recognition, promotion, self-doubt, emotional well-being, stress management, family responsibilities, and also support systems, and also the leadership qualities. The researcher documented responses in interview notes, retaining first-person wording where possible. Interviews were not audio-recorded.

Data analysis:

The researcher-recorded interview notes were reviewed as case-level accounts. Analysis followed phases informed by Braun and Clarke: familiarisation with the data; generation of initial codes; construction of candidate themes; review of themes against the dataset; definition and naming of themes; and preparation of the analysis in dialogue with the literature. The unit of coding was a meaningful account of an event, decision, or relationship. Initial codes included self-advocacy, earned promotion, uncertainty during role transitions, preparation, sponsor access, visibility, unequal recognition, care priorities, work boundaries, restorative routines, mentoring, psychological strain, perceived bias, and stakeholder navigation. Accounts that challenged a dominant interpretation were retained, including those of participants who reported little or no self-doubt. The six themes are researcher-generated interpretations. The study does not claim independent dual coding, participant validation, saturation, or formal inter-rater reliability; such claims would require supporting documentation.

Ethics, consent and confidentiality:

The researcher reports that the participants consented to publication of their responses. Participants' names and employers are omitted from the published analysis, and broad occupational descriptors are used only where needed. Further details of ethics review and consent procedures should be provided before submission.

Findings and Thematic Analysis:

The 13 participants described varied experiences. Some of reported achievement and confidence with little self-doubt; others described career frustration, difficult management practices, or emotional strain. Across these accounts, six themes illuminate personal action, relational resources, and organisational conditions relevant to professional influence and well-being.

Adaptive confidence: experience, preparation and learning:

Finding. Participants did not necessarily interpret uncertainty as evidence of inadequacy. They described confidence as developing through professional experience, preparation, continuous learning, and willingness to take on unfamiliar responsibilities.

P1 . Pharmaceutical leader: "On getting promotion said 'she had earned it', and to make it happen she shadowed a Regional Sales Head, observed how he would take decisions, understood the nuances."

P2 . Tax and consulting: “Initially was confused though also there was a wow moment with new opportunity”

P2 . Tax and consulting: “Took up the challenge saying become comfortable in uncomfortable zone”

P3 . Pharmaceutical sales leader: “There were no self-doubts the experience was much broader hence did not have problem”

P5 . Technology leader: “Do have doubts at times, but has confidence that she can work out the things has gone through market situations”

Interpretation. These accounts suggest that confidence was not simply the absence of self-doubt. Participants described drawing on experience, seeking learning opportunities, and adapting to new responsibilities. Some reported no self-doubt, which cautions against treating impostor feelings as universal.

Interpretive process: Experience → preparation and the learning → adaptive confidence

Career ownership: preparation, self-advocacy and learning:

Finding. Participants described active approaches to career advancement, including seeking promotion, building networks, preparing evidence, and challenging decisions they considered unfair.

P5 · Technology leader: “Got promoted though should have got early the preparations done was create a business case on the vision for the role and presented to the panel”

P7 · Technology consulting: “one has to define one’s own path and walk onto it,”

P8 · Risk and reputation management: “one must have a talk with seniors, transparency with guidance on what should one do, the sponsors in the organisation recommended name to the committee and it was not the manager”

P10 · Banking and housing finance: “In first job had to demand for promotion to be placed in the same position as the other equivalent.”

P13 · Talent acquisition: “Women should work on the feedback bridge the gaps and introspect on the feedback and acquire skills, upgrade be with the trend and not play the women card”

P13 · Talent acquisition: “Women should work on the feedback bridge the gaps and introspect on the feedback and acquire skills, upgrade be with the trend and not play the women card”

Interpretation. The accounts frame career advancement as involving preparation, negotiation, feedback, and professional visibility. They illustrate personal initiative without implying that outcomes are entirely within an individual’s control.

Interpretive process: Career ownership → self-advocacy and skills development → greater professional influence

Family priorities and boundary-setting:

Finding Participants described aligning career opportunities with personal circumstances, family commitments, and longer-term priorities.

P2 · Tax and consulting: “Priority lies with family; however, one has to strategies. Created a strategy and created a chart son what do I need to do for my son”

P3 · Pharmaceutical leader: “Priority is family and no prominence for titles”

P6 · Human resources leader: “for 19.5 years with no recognition for personal factors like son school day care and other for 19.5 years Priority was son and did continue inspite of no recognition.”

P7 · Technology consulting: “had personal challenges and demanding roles and accepted promotion when kid was young and kid was getting affected took decision of taking rental home near office without comprising on both family and career”

P9 · Entrepreneur: “Balanced out today, and feels that there is too much talk about work life balance but it is a requirement so go through it, and stop feeling guilty”

Interpretation. Participants presented family priorities as part of professional decision-making, not necessarily as evidence of reduced ambition. Some accounts also describe perceived professional costs associated with these choices.

Interpretive process: Clarity of priorities → Deliberate choices and the boundaries → Sustainable professional engagement

Emotional well-being: everyday coping and reflection:

Finding. Participants described exercise, creative activities, reflection, conversation as ways of navigating occupational stress.

P1 · Pharmaceutical leader: "Burnout, yes does work out at gym, or do heavy exercise this has been helping in diffusing stress"

P4 · Finance and wealth management: "I reflect and introspect, I discuss with my team, my peers and as such I don't feel burnout. I am confident of my work"

P7 · Technology consulting: "There were days of burnout, self-doubts, or what is the value of what I do, Had shared concerns with mentors and gradually realised that everybody goes through it, important to be vocal"

P8 · Risk and reputation management: "Stress and burnout and how pressure stress talks it out it helps a lot knowing that you are not alone"

P9 · Entrepreneur: "Mother has been a big support system, and son, brother also is a support Emotional support is a very private person, does a lot of journaling, take long walks and talks to oneself, does reflection"

P12 · Nonprofit leader: "has a pet dog spends time with it. Paints, Draws, Long walks, cooking. Talks to friends and vents out"

Interpretation. Participants described resilience as an ongoing personal and relational practice rather than a fixed trait. These accounts cannot establish clinical effects or show that reported coping practices prevent burnout.

Interpretive process: Emotional awareness → personal coping and relational support → restored perspective

Workplace culture, recognition and voice:

Finding Participants described contrasts between supportive managers and workplace cultures, and perceived gender bias, inadequate recognition, and limited psychological safety.

P1 · Pharmaceutical leader: "She feels that at times the recommendations she makes are not heard in a meeting or in discussions but when a male colleague gives same recom--mendation it is accepted"

P3 · Pharmaceutical leader: "There is lack of openness in the eco system hence hesitate to have a transparent conversa--tion on the deviation"

P6 · Human resources leader: "did not face imposter synd--rome but had lost self-confidence as had not got promotion for 3 years"

P8 · Risk and reputation management: "moments of loss of confidence knowing that had done a good job where there is no appreciation and that leads to doubt there is no pat on the back and very demotivating"

P11 · Investment banking: "in my organisation the work culture is nurturing environment with integrity, building relationship with stakeholders important for getting more business"

P13 · Talent acquisition: "Instances where reward or recognition did not come but had gender bias eg was expecting a leadership role and when was hired was told that will be promoted but a male was hired as the leader."

Interpretation. Participants' accounts suggest that the organisational practices may affect whether they feel their competence is recognised and their contributions heard. These are reported perceptions and are not independently verified findings of discrimination.

Interpretive process: Organisational culture → recognition and psychological safety → participation and influence

Mentoring, trusted relationships and stakeholder management:

Finding. Participants emphasised guidance, and sponsors, networks, and stakeholder relationships alongside technical capability.

P1 · Pharmaceutical leader: "Build skill set and continuously upgrade knowledge, build networks and know stakeholders well and create sponsors for oneself."

P2 · Tax and consulting: "females are always a fighter and do not want to ask help so ask for help, should also know who to aks for help"

P6 · Human resources leader: "father was mentor that guidance succeeded in helping her"

P7 · Technology consulting: "Had a good mentor and encou--rages around 2008 or 9 who gave a free hand & confidence evrnn of failutes that gave confidence and responsibilities"

P10 · Banking and housing finance: "Some time failure and loss of self confidence would speak to colleagues and guide her and to ignore"

P11 · Investment banking: "she mentored her on how MNC works and product mgt she nurtured her and taught all small nuances of the work"

P12 · Nonprofit leadership: "Patience, creating boundaries for oneself"

Interpretation. Participants described trusted relationships as serving emotional and career-development purposes. P12's extract speaks more directly to patience and boundaries than to mentoring or sponsorship.

Interpretive process: Trusted relationships → confidence and stakeholder influence → leadership growth

Variation within themes:

Table1 summarises the dominant pattern within each theme alongside accounts that qualify or diverge from it.

Table 1. Convergent patterns and divergent accounts

Theme	Dominant pattern	Exception pattern
1. Confidence	Uncertainty at transition, resolved through learning	Some reported no self-doubt; weighed personal VS professional stakes
2. Advancement pursued	Explicit self-advocacy and visibility-building	Advocacy did not always change organizational decisions
3. Family as career design	Deliberate family-first trade-offs	Some accepted larger roles by redesigning routines rather than declining
4. Ordinary practices	Everyday habits and consistent routines at times help in focusing on work	No consistency in routine and yet can manage work
5. Open transparent environment	Not always; opaque rules administered, undercurrent of biases	Nurturing managers enabled rapid growth
6. Support given	Mentors and sponsors beyond the line manager	Family support and confidence proved booster in career advancement

Cross-theme synthesis:

The themes are related but distinct. Confidence and career ownership concern personal action; family choices and coping practices illuminate values and emotional recovery; and organisational culture and mentoring concern conditions that may support or constrain influence. The accounts document participants' reported experiences, not measured causal pathways. The inclusion of participants who did not report self-doubt helps preserve variation in the analysis.

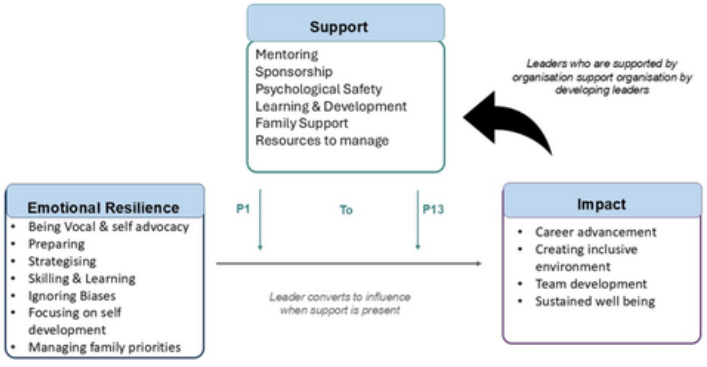
Discussion:

Interpretation in relation to previous research:

The findings complement the labyrinth perspective on leadership progression (Eagly & Carli, 2007) & scholarship on leadership identity (Ibarra et al., 2013). Participants described advancement as involving preparation, conversa--tions, adjustments, tradeoffs rather than a single successful transition. Their accounts also complicate a uniformly deficit-centred view of women's confidence: uncertainty coexisted with demonstrated competence, and while some participants reported little self-doubt. This distinction is consistent with calls for conceptual care when interpreting the impostor phenomenon (Bravata et al., 2020; Gullifor et al., 2024). Participants' accounts of exercise, reflection, and trusted conversations can be interpreted through a resource oriented approach to stress (Hobfoll, 1989; Hobfoll et al., 2018). Their descriptions of family choices and workplace experiences also resonate with research on work–family support (French et al., 2018; Kossek et al., 2011) and psychological safety (Edmondson, 1999). These are interpretive connections; the interviews do not test or verify the causal propositions of those theories.

Original contribution: a provisional Emotional Resilience–Support–Impact Framework:

The principal contribution is to move beyond treating individual resilience as an obligation to withstand difficult conditions. The proposed Self-Determination–Support–Impact Framework distinguishes: (1) purposeful individual action, including determination, preparation, advocacy, and boundary-setting; (2) organisational conditions that may enable or constrain action, such as fair recognition, flexibility, psychological safety, and sponsorship; and (3) potential professional influence and contribution, including supporting the development of others. In this framework, support is a contextual enabler, not a demonstrated causal intermediary. The framework is a provisional interpretation of the interview accounts. It has not been quantitatively tested, psychometrically validated, or shown to predict leadership outcomes. The interviews provide more direct evidence about participants' reported confidence, resource--fulness, and support than about objectively measured leadership development or organisational performance. "Impact" should therefore be treated as a proposed outcome for future investigation, not as an established finding.



Practical Implications & Recommendations:

The following recommendations are informed by the themes and the literature. They were not evaluated as interventions in this study.

Mentoring and sponsorship:

Provide confidential, trusted mentoring and sponsorship that help women gain visibility, access stretch assignments, and compete for promotion opportunities.

Stakeholder navigation:

Offer practical development in managing upward influen--cing without formal authority, and negotiating recognition, executive communication, and the building cross-functional networks.

Psychological safety and inclusive voice:

Support managers to invite disagreement, explain decisions, provide respectful feedback, examine whether employees' proposals receive equitable consideration.

Work–family flexibility:

Normalise individual negotiation of flexibility, boundary-setting, and life-stage transitions. Avoid equating visibility or constant availability with commitment.

Support for sustainable well-being:

Treat peer connection, and the clear workloads, reasonable autonomy, recovery time, and access to well-being support as organisational responsibilities, alongside recognition of individual coping practices.

Leadership development as contribution:

Assess development not only through titles and upward movement but also through mentoring, team growth, knowledge transfer, and meaningful contribution.

Limitations:

The small, heterogeneous sample of 13 professionals limits transferability and cannot represent women leaders in India or internationally. Interview notes varied in detail and were not audio-recorded or uniformly transcribed, limiting the reliability of quoted wording and the ability to revisit context. The sampling strategy, and geographic coverage, participant demographics, and interview procedures require fuller reporting. Recall and social-desirability effects uneven probing, and the researcher's professional background may have shaped the accounts and their interpretation. The study does not estimate clinical outcomes, effect sizes, or prevalence, and makes no claims of saturation or causality. The study relies on participant perspectives rather than independent verification of organisational events. Evidence about leadership impact is limited, making this component of the proposed framework more tentative than its descrip--tions of individual action and support. The ethics-review arrangements should also documented before submission.

Directions for Future Research:

Future research could use a transparent sampling strategy and, with appropriate consent, audio recordings or validated interview transcripts across industries, geographic contexts, career stages. Quantitative measures could be introduced to assess constructs identified in this exploratory study. Comparative organisational studies could examine mento--ring, sponsorship, psychological safety, fair recognition. Mixed-methods research could further examine about the proposed framework using validated measures alongside qualitative accounts, and while retaining the attention to experiences that do not fit a single narrative.

Conclusion:

The interviews portray experienced women professionals who draw on accumulated experience and competence and view learning as an ongoing process. Some participants described situational decreases in confidence or self-doubt following disappointment; they also described responding through reflection, acceptance, support, or renewed effort. Participants made active decisions about family and career priorities, although such choices could involve perceived costs to career progression. Their accounts further suggest that workplace climates and trusted relationships shape their experiences, while exercise and hobbies were among the personal practices participants used to manage stress. Moving beyond resilience therefore requires more than asking women to cope more effectively. Organisations also have a role in creating psychologically safe environments, providing mentoring and sponsorship, developing skills, and enabling purposeful professional action to contribute to leadership. This includes recognising family responsibilities and providing resources and flexibility where possible. Supportive conditions may help women sustain leadership and contribute to the development of others, although this study does not establish those effects. The proposed Self-Determination–Support–Impact Framework is a testable interpretive proposition, not an established causal model.

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Appendix A. Illustrative code-to-theme mapping:

Confidence in transition. Indicative codes: earned compe--tence; initial uncertainty; stretching beyond familiar tasks. Interpretive claim: The Confidence may be demonstrated through adaptive learning rather than the absence of apprehension. Career self-determination. Indicative codes: self-advocacy; preparation; promotion requests; sponsor visibility. Interpretive claim: Advancement accounts feature purposeful action and negotiation. Values and boundaries. Indicative codes: care responsibilities; prioritisation; time limits; career trade-offs. The Interpretive claim: Family commitments can coexist with meaningful professional ambition. Regulation & recovery. Indicative codes: exercise; hobbies; peer conversations; problem-solving. Interpretive claim: Everyday practices may support perspective but cannot substitute for healthy work design. Organisational voice. Indicative codes: respectful management; perceived bias; inclusion in decisions; recognition. Interpretive claim: Workplace environments may also influence whether the capabilities are heard and rewarded. Relational leadership. Indicative codes: mentorship; and coaching; networks; stakeholder influence; developing others. Interpretive claim: Supportive relationships may connect self-management with collective leadership.